

Yugo Iwamoto

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Overview

Doctoral student in Information Science and Technology at George Mason University and Human–Computer Interaction (HCI) researcher studying young people’s experiences with AI and personalized digital technologies. Working with Nora McDonald, I investigate how these systems shape adolescents’ identities, trust, social relationships, autonomy, and agency, with the goal of supporting safer and more reflective engagement with AI. A complementary strand of my research focuses on accessibility and human-centered generative AI, particularly how generative systems can help people create and evaluate accessible descriptions of complex scientific figures. Across these projects, I use participatory design, iterative prototyping, and mixed-methods research to develop evidence-based guidance for more responsible, inclusive, and human-centered technology.

Research Interests: Human–Computer Interaction (HCI); Youth-Centered Human–AI Interaction; AI, Identity, Trust, and Adolescent Autonomy; Personalized and Generative AI; Human-Centered AI for Sensemaking and Verification; Interactive Tools for Reading and Reasoning with Scientific and Technical Content; Accessible Figure Description and Assistive Authoring Workflows; Participatory and Co-Design; Mixed-Methods Evaluation.

Education

Ph.D. in Information Science and Technology, George Mason University (GMU), Fairfax, VA, US
Aug 2026 – May 2031 (expected)

Relevant Coursework: Project Management Concepts & Methods

M.S. in Human-Computer Interaction, Rochester Institute of Technology (RIT), NY, US

Aug 2023 – Aug 2025 | CGPA: 3.78

Capstone: Bridge Communications: Kiosk Multimodal Communications tool for hearing and d/DHH users.

Relevant Coursework: Research Methods, Usability Testing, Wearable and IoT, Designing Information, Web Development I & II, Foundations of HCI

B.S. in Communications & Recreation (Recreation and Tourism), State University of New York (SUNY) at Brockport, NY, US

Jan 2018 – Dec 2021 | CGPA: 3.37

Relevant Coursework: Advertising Communications, Tourism Marketing, Foundations of Tourism Marketing, Interpersonal Communications, Recreation Management, Conflict Management

Research Experience

Graduate Research Assistant – George Mason University, Aug 2026 – Present

- Conduct research in Human–Computer Interaction under the supervision of Dr. Nora McDonald, focusing on youth online safety, accessibility, and human-centered AI.
- Design and conduct grant-supported studies, including developing research protocols, collecting data, and preparing data for analysis.
- Analyze research findings and prepare manuscripts for submission to leading peer-reviewed HCI venues.

NSF AWARE-AI Research Trainee – AWARE-AI NRT, RIT, Aug 2024 – Present

- Human-Computer Interaction Track under Dr. Jamison Heard and Dr. Garreth Tigwell
- Designed and evaluated GenAI-assisted workflows for scientific-figure image descriptions with disability service professionals (mixed-methods: rubric scoring + interviews).
- Analyzed mixed-methods data, both qualitative and quantitative, and collaborated with disability service professionals.
- Accepted Work in Progress/Poster paper at ASSETS 2025: “Exploring Generative AI to Support Disability Service Professionals in Writing Image Descriptions for HCI Science Figures.”
- Applied participatory design principles in evaluating generative AI-supported tools with accessibility professionals.

Graduate Research Assistant – School of Information, RIT, Aug 2024 – May 2025

- Assisted Associate Professor Catherine Beaton
- Designed and evaluated inclusive digital platforms for faculty with disabilities and launched a website for the project.
- Developed and prepared generative AI for K-12 underfunded school workshops, targeting teachers to enrich their course materials.
- Led studies on GenAI in K-12 and multilingual STEM education.

Capstone Project – Kiosk real-time speech-to-text tool for inclusive conversations between hearing and DHH users, Aug 2024 – July 2026 | Rochester Institute of Technology, NY

- Committee Chair: Dr. Tae Oh and Committee Member: Dr. Michael McQuaid
- Developed a real-time speech-to-text prototype using an API to support conversations between Deaf/Hard-of-Hearing (DHH) and hearing individuals. Prototype is [here](#)
- Conducted user-centered design research and usability testing with DHH and hearing participants and analyzed both qualitative and quantitative data (NASA TLX, interviews).
- Focused on inclusive communication, assistive technology, and accessibility innovation in everyday environments.
- Published and presented at the 2026 Human Computer Interaction International (HCII)

Selected Publications & Presentations

1. **Y. Iwamoto**, M. Raees, T. Oh, and M. McQuaid. 2026. Bridge Communications: Kiosk Multimodal Communication Tool for d/Deaf and Hard of Hearing and Hearing. In Proceedings of the 28th International Conference on Human-Computer Interaction (HCII' 26), Springer, https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-032-29656-6_13
2. M. Raees, **Y. Iwamoto***, K. Pagangelis, J. Heard, and G Tigwell. 2026. How University Disability Services Professionals Write Image Descriptions for HCI Figures Using Generative AI. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2602.08937*
3. **Y. Iwamoto**, M. Raees*, J. Heard, and G. Tigwell. 2025. Exploring Generative AI to Support Disability Service Professionals in Writing Image Descriptions for HCI Science Figures. In Proceedings of the 28th International ACM SIGACCESS Conference on Computers and Accessibility (ASSETS '25). ACM, New York, NY, USA. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3663547.3759763>
4. **Y. Iwamoto**, C. Beaton, and A. Roberts. 2025. Digital Literacy and AI in Underfunded Schools. In the IEEE STEM Education Conference (Workshop), Princeton University. IEEE.
5. **Y. Iwamoto**, A. Roberts, R. Mahajan, C. Beaton. 2025. Importance of Diverse Role Models in Education to Support Equal Education Opportunity and Inclusivity. *2025 IEEE Integrated STEM Education Conference (ISEC)*, 1–6. <https://doi.org/10.1109/isec64801.2025.11147317>
6. **Y. Iwamoto** and M. Raees*. 2025. A1ly: Improving Alt-Text for Science Figures with GenAI. In the Graduate Showcase (Poster & Oral Presentation), Rochester Institute of Technology.
7. C. Beaton, E. Weeden, A. Roberts, and **Y. Iwamoto**. 2024. Being Included: Institute Benefits in Supporting Inclusivity for Disabled Faculty in Higher Education. In ICERI2024 Proceedings, 5648–5654.

*Equal Contribution

Technical & UX Skills

Programming: Python, HTML, CSS, JavaScript, PHP, MySQL, C++, JSON

Research: Research-through-design, thematic analysis, mixed-methods research, statistical analysis, accessibility audits, participatory design, user study, literature review, qualitative research

UX & Design: Figma, Wireframing, Usability Testing, Adobe CC, Responsive Design

Tools: WordPress, Blackboard, Arduino, JMP, Microsoft 365, Google Suite, Render

Professional Experience

Summer IT Specialist – Greece Central School District (GCSD)

Jun 2026 – Aug 2026 | Greece, NY

- Set up, transported, and installed computer hardware and peripherals across school sites to support district technology operations during summer recess.

- Supported equipment deployment by boxing, unboxing, organizing, and preparing desktops and related technology items for installation and replacement.
- Helped troubleshoot basic hardware and system issues and assisted technology staff with computer-related projects requiring reliability, flexibility, and attention to detail.

Graduate Assistant – *Disability Services Office, Rochester Institute of Technology*

Jan 2024 – May 2025 | Rochester, NY

- Provided accessibility support and assistive technology solutions for students with disabilities.
- Ensured equitable access by coordinating academic accommodations across various disciplines.
- Supported exam proctoring, technical troubleshooting, and content conversion for screen reader compatibility.

Communications & Student Experience Coordinator – *RIT School of Information*

Jan 2022 – Dec 2022 | Rochester, NY

- Led digital content strategy and social media; supervised student ambassadors.
- Managed web projects, content creation, and user-centered site enhancements.
- Supported research publication promotion

Communications Intern – *Gates Chili Central School District*

Jan 2021 – Jun 2021 | Rochester, NY

- Created multilingual and accessible digital content for community engagement.
- Updated and maintained web presence with a focus on inclusive design.
- Supported communication across cultural and linguistic backgrounds.

Receptionist – *Woodcliff Hotel and Spa*

Aug 2021 – Dec 2021 | Fairport, NY

- Handled guest services, events, and hospitality logistics.
- Supported the banquet team for weddings and special events as a server, people mover driver, and assisting servers
- Supported revenue management from a guest service standpoint.

Purser, High-Speed Rail Attendant – *Japan Rail Central Passengers*

May 2018 – Aug 2020 | Osaka, Japan

- Delivered bilingual customer service and coordinated on-board operations.
- Assisted passengers with special needs and improved the trip experience.
- Ensured efficient, safe, and punctual operation of bullet train services.

Leadership & Community Engagement

1. **International Orientation Leader** – SUNY Brockport, 2018–2020
2. **President of the International Student Organization** – SUNY Brockport, 2018-2021

3. **Global Ambassador for Study Abroad Programs** – SUNY Brockport, 2019–2020

Achievements, Honors & Awards

1. **Graduate Research Assistant Scholarship** (2024–2025)
2. **Dean's List Honors** – SUNY Brockport (2019–2021)
3. **International Transfer Student Merit-Based Scholarship** (2018-2020)
4. **GCCSD Pride Award** – Gates Chili Central School District (2021)
5. **Employee of the Month**- Woodcliff Hotel and Spa (2021)

Funding

1. **Graduate School Research & Creative Fundings:** – RIT; \$500 (2025)

Language

1. English– Native
2. Japanese– Native
3. Danish-Basic (currently learning)

Academic/ Research Reference

1. **Dr. Jamison Heard** (jrheee@rit.edu) – Assistant Professor at RIT, Supervisor for NSF AWARE AI Traineeship
2. **Dr. Catherine Beaton** (ciiics@rit.edu) – Associate Professor at RIT, Supervisor for Graduate Research Assistant
3. **Dr. Tae Oh** (thoics@rit.edu) – Professor at RIT, Committee Chair for MS Capstone Project
4. **Dr. Michael McQuaid** (micmcquaid@gmail.com) – Associate Professor at UT Austin, MS Capstone Committee Member
5. **Mrs. Betty Hillman** (echics@rit.edu) – Assistant Director at RIT, Previous Supervisor for Coordinator of Communications and Student Experience